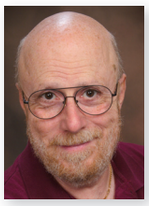
Kurt Hertzog on turning materials other than wood

The world beyond wood

KURT HERTZOG



Kurt is a professional woodturner, demonstrator and teacher and writes for various woodturning and woodworking publications in the United States as well as contributing to *Woodturning* magazine. He is on the Pen Makers' Guild Council and is currently president of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW).

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With more than 100,000 species of woods in the world, most turners shouldn't have a need to look to other materials. The variety of characteristics and colourations these species present to the woodturning community should fulfil every real and perceived need. That said, however, there is a world of other materials that can easily be turned on your lathe with your existing woodturning tools and equipment. This month we'll feature just a few of them and hopefully kickstart your exploration if you haven't already ventured off the path of wood. Be aware, though, that this is only the tip of the iceberg. There are metals, plastics, bone, antler, stone and others galore. The selected items for presentation here are intended to be just a starter. Using them should need no additional tools or equipment beyond what is probably already in your workshop and kit. We'll touch on just a few very readily available materials to get you going on your journey beyond wood.

Safety

In addition to the use of PPE for the standard woodturning safety including eye, face and breathing protection as needed, special considerations need to be taken. When turning metals, long shards of curled metal may be strung around the material or tools. The innate habit to brush off this debris presents very serious cut hazards. These curled bits of metal can be incredibly sharp creating very serious cut hazards with the simplest of contact. Always stop the machinery before attempting to remove any debris and especially when turning metals. Even with the lathe stopped or trying to remove debris curled around the tool, use caution to prevent being cut. A chip brush or a cut-proof carving glove to brush away any metal cutting debris is a wise idea.

In addition to the usual safety precautions, working with metals can present cut hazards if careless

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